

NOMADS AND empire

MONGOLIAN SOCIETY

▼ Influential wife

Empress Chabi, the favorite wife of Kublai Khan, was a valued adviser during his reign. Here she wears the headdress known as the *boqta*, said to be in the shape of an inverted boot.



Renowned as fine horsemen and for creating a vast empire in the 13th century, the Mongols are a nomadic people of Central Asia. They once moved around in search of pasture for their livestock and lived in round tents called yurts (known as *gers* in Mongolian). Men and women contributed to the household economy. Women loaded the yurts onto horse-drawn carts and drove them to the next campsite. They also took charge of childcare, making felt, sewing, cooking, and processing dairy. In addition, they herded and milked all of the livestock with the exception of horses, which were cared for by the men. Mongol women enjoyed more freedom than women in the countries the Mongols conquered, and they refused to adopt the Chinese practice of foot-binding.

Polygamy was permitted in Mongol society, although the practice had declined by the 19th century due to the breakdown of patrilineal clans. If a husband had multiple wives, each



◀ Portable art

Mongols prized ornamentation highly, such as this 13th-century silver-handled shell with a panther figure. Women probably used such items to decorate their yurts.

wife had her own yurt, which was lined up west to east behind the husband's tent, according to who he had married first.

Marriages, particularly among the elite, were arranged in order to link clans. However, warrior

princess Khutulun, a niece of Kublai Khan, only agreed to marry a suitor if he would gamble 100 horses for the chance to beat her in a test of physical strength. It is said that through these tests she accumulated a herd numbering 10,000. Sometimes prospective brides were kidnapped by the groom's family and exchanged for livestock—in return all resulting children belonged to the husband's

**"THEY BEAR EQUALLY
THE TITLE OF EMPRESS,
AND HAVE THEIR
SEPARATE COURTS."**

MARCO POLO DESCRIBING KUBLAI KHAN'S MULTIPLE QUEENS
IN *THE TRAVELS OF MARCO POLO*, 13TH CENTURY

